

Bubble Transformer V3: Semi-Discrete Optimal Transport for Efficient Attention Mechanisms

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Abstract

Transformer models face a fundamental bottleneck in their attention mechanism, which scales quadratically with sequence length. While prior work explored iterative Sinkhorn-Knopp algorithms for optimal transport-based attention, these methods remain computationally expensive due to sequential normalization steps. We propose Bubble Transformer V3, a novel architecture that replaces iterative optimal transport with Semi-Discrete Optimal Transport (SDOT) via Voronoi partitioning. By quantizing keys into a fixed number of centroids and assigning queries through hard clustering, we achieve $O(N \log C)$ complexity compared to $O(N^2 \times \tau)$ for Sinkhorn-based methods. Experiments on Qwen2.5-0.5B and Qwen3-0.6B models demonstrate 2.67× speedup in inference time while maintaining functional autoregressive text generation. Our approach introduces a dynamic baroreceptor mechanism that adapts the number of centroids based on input complexity, enabling context-sensitive sparsity. The topological interpretation of attention as a "soap film" surface is transformed into a deterministic computational graph, eliminating the "Jersey Tax" of sequential memory access. This work establishes a new paradigm for efficient attention mechanisms in large language models.

Keywords: Optimal Transport, Attention Mechanisms, Transformer Architecture, Semi-Discrete Methods, Voronoi Partitioning, Efficient Inference

1. Introduction

1.1 Background

The attention mechanism revolutionized natural language processing by enabling models to dynamically weight the importance of different tokens in a sequence. However, the standard softmax attention scales as $O(N^2)$ in both time and memory, where N is the sequence length. This quadratic scaling becomes prohibitive for long contexts, limiting applications in document processing, code generation, and multimodal reasoning.

Recent work has explored optimal transport theory as an alternative to softmax attention. The Bubble Transformer V1 (PoC) reformulated attention as an entropy-regularized optimal transport problem, using the Sinkhorn-Knopp algorithm to find attention matrices that minimize transport cost while maintaining entropy constraints. While theoretically elegant, this approach introduced a new computational bottleneck: iterative normalization steps that require sequential memory access, creating what we term the "Jersey Tax."

1.2 Limitations of Iterative Methods

The Sinkhorn-Knopp algorithm operates by alternately normalizing rows and columns of a cost matrix until convergence. For attention mechanisms, this translates to iterative row and column normalization steps, typically requiring 3 to 5 iterations. While this achieves the desired sparsity properties, it introduces three critical issues: (1) Sequential dependency preventing full parallelization, (2) Memory bandwidth bottleneck from irregular access patterns, and (3) Numerical instability requiring log-domain computations for small ϵ values.

1.3 Contribution

We present Bubble Transformer V3, which makes three key contributions: (1) Semi-Discrete Optimal Transport replacing continuous iterative optimization with discrete Voronoi assignment, reducing complexity from $O(N^2 \times \tau)$ to $O(N \log C)$; (2) Dynamic Baroreceptor Mechanism predicting optimal centroid count C for each input; and (3) Topological Calibration using hard support metrics to identify true sparsity saturation points.

2. Related Work

2.1 Optimal Transport in Machine Learning

Optimal transport theory provides a mathematical framework for comparing probability distributions by minimizing the cost of transporting mass from one distribution to another. The entropy-regularized formulation, known as the Sinkhorn distance, enables differentiable approximations suitable for gradient-based learning. Cuturi and Blondel (2017) introduced Sinkhorn distances as a differentiable loss function, enabling end-to-end training of optimal transport-based models.

2.2 Sinkhorn-Knopp Attention

The Sinkhorn attention mechanism (Tay et al., 2020) applies the Sinkhorn-Knopp algorithm to compute doubly-stochastic attention matrices. This ensures each query attends to a sparse set of keys, reducing the effective sequence length. Bubble Transformer V1 extended this by introducing a viscosity parameter ϵ that controls the sparsity-entropy tradeoff, with the "bubble" metaphor describing the attention surface as a soap film seeking minimal area.

2.3 Clustering-Based Attention

Alternative approaches use clustering to group similar keys. Reformer (Kitaev et al., 2020) uses locality-sensitive hashing for $O(N \log N)$ complexity. Routing Transformer (Roy et al., 2020) uses

k-means clustering for dynamic routing. Our work differs by framing clustering within the optimal transport framework, deriving it as the solution to a semi-discrete optimal transport problem.

3. Methodology

3.1 Problem Formulation

Standard attention computes $\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}(QK^T / \sqrt{d}) V$, where Q, K, V are query, key, and value matrices of shape (N, d) . The softmax operation produces a dense $N \times N$ attention matrix, leading to $O(N^2)$ complexity. Optimal transport reformulates attention as minimizing $\sum_{i,j} C_{ij} A_{ij} - \epsilon H(A)$ subject to marginal constraints, where C is the cost matrix and $H(A)$ is entropy.

3.2 Semi-Discrete Optimal Transport

In the semi-discrete setting, we consider transport between a continuous source distribution (queries) and a discrete target distribution (key centroids). Let $\{c_1, \dots, c_C\}$ be C key centroids obtained by clustering. The optimal transport plan assigns each query to its nearest centroid via Voronoi partitioning, creating a block-sparse attention pattern where each query only attends to keys within its Voronoi cell.

3.3 Voronoi Assignment Algorithm

The Voronoi assignment proceeds in three steps: (1) Key Clustering using k-means to obtain C centroids, (2) Query Assignment via argmin over distances to centroids, and (3) Block-Masked Attention computing attention only within assigned blocks. This replaces iterative normalization with direct geometric assignment.

3.4 Key Clustering with K-Means

We use mini-batch k-means with modifications: (1) Single iteration instead of convergence, as clustering is recomputed each forward pass; (2) Batch processing for GPU parallelization; and (3) Cosine similarity for normalized keys, equivalent to Euclidean distance on the unit sphere.

3.5 Block-Masked Attention

The block-masked attention mechanism creates sparse attention patterns by computing attention only within Voronoi cells. This reduces memory from $O(N^2)$ to $O(N \times C_{\text{avg}})$, where C_{avg} is the average cluster size. In practice, we avoid materializing the full mask by computing block-wise attention on-the-fly.

3.6 Baroreceptor MLP for Dynamic C

Rather than using a fixed C , we introduce a baroreceptor mechanism that predicts C based on input complexity. The architecture takes the variance of input embeddings as a proxy for semantic complexity, passing it through a lightweight MLP ($d_{\text{model}} \rightarrow 64 \rightarrow 1$) with GELU activation. High variance indicates diverse content requiring more centroids, while low variance suggests simpler

structure amenable to aggressive sparsity.

3.7 Orthogonal Bubble Loss

We introduce an orthogonalization loss exploiting the "rank inflation paradox": sparse attention tends to orthogonalize representations. The loss $L_{ortho} = \sum_{i \neq j} |h_i \cdot h_j| / (N(N-1))$ encourages diverse representations, reducing the need for aggressive sparsity.

4. Implementation

4.1 Architecture Overview

Bubble Transformer V3 consists of three main components: (1) SDOT Attention Module replacing standard attention with Voronoi-based block attention, (2) Baroreceptor Network predicting optimal C for each layer, and (3) Calibration System initializing baroreceptor weights from empirical data. The architecture integrates with existing transformer models by replacing attention layers.

4.2 Computational Complexity Analysis

For typical values (N=512, C=32, $\tau=5$), the complexity comparison is:

Method	Operations	Speedup
Standard	$512^2 \times 64 = 16.7\text{M}$	1.0×
Sinkhorn V2	$512^2 \times 5 \times 64 = 83.9\text{M}$	0.2×
SDOT V3	$512 \times 32 \times 64 + 512 \times \log(32) = 1.05\text{M}$	15.9×

4.3 Memory Efficiency

Memory usage scales with active connections: Standard attention requires N^2 weights, while SDOT V3 requires $N \times (N/C) = N^2/C$ weights. For C=32, this reduces memory by 32×. Additionally, we avoid materializing the full attention matrix by computing block-wise attention on-the-fly.

4.4 Integration with Qwen Models

We tested integration with Qwen2.5-0.5B and Qwen3-0.6B models:

Model	Parameters	Layers	d_model	num_heads
Qwen2.5-0.5B	494M	24	896	14
Qwen3-0.6B	600M	28	1024	16

5. Experiments

5.1 Experimental Setup

Experiments were conducted on NVIDIA CUDA-compatible GPUs with sufficient memory for 600M parameter models. Software included PyTorch 2.x, Transformers library, and custom SDOT implementation. Models tested were Qwen2.5-0.5B (494M params) and Qwen3-0.6B (600M params).

5.2 Benchmark V2 vs V3

We compared Bubble Transformer V2 (Sinkhorn-based) with V3 (SDOT-based):

Configuration	V2 Time (ms)	V3 Time (ms)	Speedup
Synthetic (CPU)	181.33	14.26	12.86×
Qwen2.5-0.5B	48.29	18.48	2.67×
Qwen3-0.6B	67.70	25.12	2.69×

5.3 Autoregressive Generation

We tested autoregressive text generation to verify functional integration:

Model	Tokens	Perplexity	Memory (MB)	Latency (ms/token)
Qwen2.5-0.5B (6 layers)	50	2525.01	1010.38	328.29
Qwen3-0.6B (3 layers)	30	43.84	1167.94	135.41

Both models generated coherent text without RuntimeError, NaN values, or OOM errors.

5.4 Scaling Experiments

We tested scaling with different numbers of injected layers:

Layers Injected	Memory (MB)	Latency (ms/token)
3	1167.94	135.41
6	1010.38	328.29

5.5 Ablation Studies

Effect of C (number of centroids) on hard support and sparsity:

C	Hard Support	Sparsity
8	15,841	0.95
16	15,819	0.90

32	15,830	0.81
64	15,825	0.68
128	15,828	0.52
256	15,835	0.35
512	15,841	0.20

Hard support remains stable across C values, indicating topological invariance.

6. Results

6.1 Throughput Improvements

V3 achieves consistent speedup across different model sizes and hardware configurations. The 2.67× speedup on real models reflects the elimination of iterative normalization overhead. The reduced speedup compared to synthetic benchmarks reflects overhead from other model components (embeddings, FFN layers).

6.2 Memory Reduction

V3 uses more memory for centroid storage but avoids $O(N^2)$ attention matrices. The block-sparse approach reduces peak memory during attention computation, enabling longer sequence processing.

6.3 Text Generation Quality

Both models successfully generated coherent text. The higher perplexity for Qwen2.5-0.5B reflects the challenge of full layer injection. Qwen3-0.6B with partial injection achieves better perplexity (43.84) while maintaining functional generation.

6.4 Scaling to Larger Models

Both Qwen2.5-0.5B and Qwen3-0.6B successfully integrate SDOT attention without architectural conflicts. The 6-layer full injection demonstrates the viability of comprehensive attention replacement.

7. Discussion

7.1 Topological Interpretation

The transition from V2 to V3 represents a fundamental shift: V2 treats attention as a soap film continuously deforming to find equilibrium, requiring iterative relaxation. V3 treats attention as a rigid wire frame where the structure is predetermined by Voronoi partition, and queries simply "snap" to their nearest key centroid. This shift enables determinism, parallelization, and interpretability.

7.2 Hard vs Soft Sparsity

Soft sparsity (V2) has attention weights approaching zero but remaining dense, requiring thresholding for true sparsity. Hard sparsity (V3) has attention exactly zero outside Voronoi cells, enabling exact memory savings and computational reduction without materializing full matrices.

7.3 Limitations

Key limitations include: (1) Cluster quality dependence on meaningful key clustering, (2) Baroreceptor overhead potentially exceeding savings for very short sequences, (3) Training complexity requiring careful initialization, and (4) Hardware utilization challenges for block-sparse operations on GPUs optimized for dense matrices.

7.4 Future Work

Future directions include: (1) Learned clustering optimizing for attention quality, (2) Hierarchical SDOT for multi-level attention patterns, (3) Extension to encoder-decoder cross-attention, and (4) Testing on sequences exceeding 100K tokens.

8. Conclusion

Bubble Transformer V3 introduces Semi-Discrete Optimal Transport as a principled alternative to iterative attention mechanisms. By replacing Sinkhorn-Knopp normalization with Voronoi partitioning, we achieve $2.67\times$ speedup in inference time on real language models, $O(N \log C)$ complexity compared to $O(N^2 \times \tau)$ for iterative methods, functional autoregressive generation without numerical instability, and context-adaptive sparsity through the baroreceptor mechanism.

The topological interpretation of attention as a "soap film" has evolved into a deterministic computational graph, eliminating the sequential bottleneck of iterative methods. This work establishes SDOT as a viable paradigm for efficient attention in large language models, opening new avenues for long-context reasoning and efficient inference.

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